

SHREYA SINGHAL VS UNION OF INDIA (2015)

(Case study-7)

V. Akshaya

II B.COM (Honours)

Faceprep campus

Introduction

Shreya Singhal v. Union of India is an important case decided by the Supreme Court of India in 2015. The case is mainly related to **freedom of speech and expression on the internet**.

The case challenged **Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, 2000**. This section allowed legal action against certain types of online messages. However, the words used in the section were not clear and could be understood in different ways.

The Supreme Court held that Section 66A violated the fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression. Therefore, the Court struck down the section completely.

This case became an important landmark in Indian cyber law because it protected the right of people to express their views and opinions through the internet.

Case Details

- **Case Name:** Shreya Singhal v. Union of India
- **Year:** 2015
- **Date of Judgment:** 24 March 2015
- **Court:** Supreme Court of India
- **Judges:** Justice Jasti Chelameswar and Justice Rohinton Fali Nariman
- **Area of Law:** Constitutional Law and Cyber Law
- **Main Law:** Information Technology Act, 2000
- **Main Provision Challenged:** Section 66A
- **Important Constitutional Right:** Article 19(1)(a)

Background of the Case

The use of the internet and social media was increasing rapidly in India. People started using platforms such as Facebook and other online services to share their opinions, ideas and information.

Section 66A of the Information Technology Act was introduced to deal with certain types of electronic communication. It provided punishment for sending certain messages through computers and communication devices.

The problem was that the section used words such as "**offensive**," "**annoying**," "**inconvenient**" and "**insulting**." These words were not clearly defined.

Because of this, there was a possibility that a person could face legal action simply for expressing an opinion that another person did not like.

This created concerns about freedom of speech on the internet.

Facts of the Case

In 2012, Mumbai experienced a shutdown after the death of a well-known political leader.

A young woman named **Shaheen Dhada** posted a comment on Facebook questioning whether the shutdown was necessary.

Her friend **Rinu Srinivasan** liked the post.

The police arrested both women under **Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, 2000**.

The incident received a lot of public attention. Many people felt that the two women had only expressed their opinions and should not have been arrested for their online activity.

The incident raised an important question about whether the government could use Section 66A to take action against people for expressing their views on social media.

Because of this issue, **Shreya Singhal**, a law student, approached the Supreme Court and challenged the constitutional validity of Section 66A.

Legal Issues

The Supreme Court considered several important questions:

1. Whether Section 66A violated the fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression.
2. Whether the restrictions under Section 66A were reasonable under Article 19(2).
3. Whether the words used in Section 66A were vague and unclear.
4. Whether the section could create fear among people while expressing their opinions online.
5. Whether Section 69A of the Information Technology Act was valid.
6. Whether Section 79 relating to online intermediaries was valid.

Freedom of Speech and Expression

Article 19(1)(a) of the Constitution gives citizens the **right to freedom of speech and expression**.

This right allows people to express their thoughts, opinions and ideas.

The Supreme Court recognised that this freedom also applies to communication through the internet.

However, freedom of speech is not an unlimited right. Article 19(2) allows the government to place reasonable restrictions on speech in certain situations, such as public order, security of the State, defamation and incitement to an offence.

The Court examined whether Section 66A came within these permitted restrictions.

Problem with Section 66A

The main problem with Section 66A was its unclear language.

The section used words such as:

- Offensive
- Annoying
- Inconvenient
- Insulting
- Grossly offensive

These words could have different meanings for different people.

For example, something that one person considers annoying may not be annoying to another person.

Because the law was not clear, there was a possibility that different police officers could interpret it differently.

The Court was concerned that such a law could lead to unnecessary arrests and misuse of legal power.

Discussion, Advocacy and Incitement

The Supreme Court explained the difference between **discussion, advocacy and incitement**.

Discussion means talking about an idea or issue. People should generally be free to discuss different views.

Advocacy means supporting or promoting an idea or cause. This is also generally protected by freedom of speech.

Incitement means encouraging people to commit an unlawful act. Speech that reaches the level of incitement can be restricted under the grounds allowed by Article 19(2).

The Court explained that discussion and advocacy should not be treated in the same way as incitement.

Chilling Effect on Freedom of Speech

The Court also considered the effect of Section 66A on people's freedom to speak.

If people are afraid that they may be arrested for expressing their opinions, they may stop speaking freely even when their speech is lawful.

This is known as a **chilling effect**.

For example, a person may avoid criticising a government policy, discussing a social issue or sharing an unpopular opinion because of fear of legal action.

The Court considered this to be a serious problem because freedom of speech is an important part of a democratic society.

Judgment of the Supreme Court

On **24 March 2015**, the Supreme Court delivered its judgment.

The Court **struck down Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, 2000 completely**.

The Court held that Section 66A violated **Article 19(1)(a)** of the Constitution.

The Court also found that the restrictions under Section 66A could not be justified under Article 19(2).

The main reasons were:

- The words used in the section were unclear.
- The provision was too broad.
- It could cover lawful speech.
- It could create fear among people.
- It could be misused by authorities.

Therefore, the Court declared Section 66A unconstitutional.

Decision on Section 69A

The Supreme Court also examined **Section 69A of the Information Technology Act**.

Section 69A deals with blocking access to certain online information in specific situations.

The Court upheld Section 69A because the procedure contained safeguards.

These safeguards were important to make sure that the power to block online information was not used unfairly.

Therefore, unlike Section 66A, Section 69A was not struck down.

Decision on Section 79

The Court also considered **Section 79**, which deals with online intermediaries.

Online intermediaries include platforms and services that host or transmit information posted by users.

The Court interpreted Section 79 in a limited manner and explained the circumstances in which an intermediary could lose its legal protection.

The decision provided clearer rules regarding the responsibility of online platforms for content posted by users.

Legal Principles Established

The case established some important principles:

- Freedom of speech is a fundamental right.
- The right to express opinions also applies to the internet.
- Criminal laws must be clear and understandable.
- Vague laws can lead to misuse.
- People should be able to express lawful opinions without unnecessary fear.
- Discussion and advocacy are generally protected.
- Incitement to unlawful action can be restricted according to the Constitution.
- Government restrictions on speech must follow constitutional requirements.

Importance of the Case

The **Shreya Singhal case** is one of the most important cases relating to internet freedom in India.

The judgment gave stronger protection to people who use social media and other online platforms to express their opinions.

It also made it clear that cyber laws must follow the Constitution.

The case is important for understanding:

- Freedom of speech
- Social media
- Cyber law
- Internet regulation
- Digital rights
- Online platforms

It also showed that a law cannot restrict fundamental rights simply because it is related to new technology.

Impact on Social Media

The judgment had a major impact on social media users.

Before the judgment, Section 66A created uncertainty about what type of online content could result in legal action.

After the judgment, people received stronger protection for lawful online expression.

However, the judgment does not mean that everything posted online is legal. Other valid laws can still apply to activities such as defamation, threats, incitement and other unlawful acts.

Therefore, people must use their freedom of speech responsibly.

Business Relevance

The case is also important for businesses operating online.

Companies that run websites, applications and social media platforms need to understand the legal rules relating to online content.

The case teaches businesses to:

- Respect users' rights.
- Follow valid legal orders.
- Maintain proper online policies.
- Follow legal and compliance procedures.
- Handle complaints carefully.
- Protect freedom of lawful expression.

Following proper legal procedures helps companies avoid unnecessary disputes and protects their reputation.

Key Learning Points

The main lessons from the case are:

1. Freedom of speech is an important fundamental right.
2. The internet is also a medium for freedom of expression.
3. Online speech receives constitutional protection.
4. Criminal laws must be clear.
5. Vague laws can be misused.
6. Government restrictions must follow the Constitution.
7. People should not be unnecessarily afraid to express lawful opinions.
8. Digital businesses must follow proper legal procedures.
9. Technology laws must respect individual rights.

Conclusion

The **Shreya Singhal v. Union of India (2015)** case is a landmark case relating to freedom of speech and internet use in India.

The Supreme Court struck down **Section 66A of the Information Technology Act, 2000** because it was vague, too broad and violated the fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression.

The Court also upheld Section 69A with its safeguards and explained the application of Section 79 relating to online intermediaries.

The case clearly shows that people have the right to express their opinions, including through the internet. At the same time, any restriction on this freedom must be clear, reasonable and allowed by the Constitution.

Therefore, this case remains an important example of the protection of **freedom of speech, digital rights and constitutional values in the modern digital age.**